



Madhesh

Defined by Ethnicity for Equality

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"I hereby end my career in the mainstream..." Aadarsh Mishra, a comedian, tweeted about his retirement from mainstream, which was due to the ethnic discrimination from a judge at Comedy Champion, a comedy show, in which he had participated. Aadarsh Mishra recedes from Bara, a district located in the Terai region of Nepal. The Terai region holds a history of various political uprisings and revolts, which have led to significant socio-political transformations in Nepal, among which the spark of the Biratnagar Jute Mill's strike led to a nationwide Satyagraha, ultimately uprooting the entire Rana Regime.(incident of importance of terai)

Later, Terai seemed to be entangled with its own politics for their representation. It turned out to be a complex arena for social, political and geopolitical plays. That's when the term 'Madhesh' was introduced, as mentioned by Jason Milklian in his paper published in 2008. Although both the terms seem alike, yet 'Terai' is used specifically in geographical context whereas 'Madhesh' is preferred as a socio-political terminology. Madheshi is a term used to denote Indo-Aryan people who are settled in the Terai region of Nepal from Indian origins, mostly from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar after the 1860's; thus still sharing cultural and linguistic similarity.

As mentioned by Frederick H Gaize in his book "Regionalism and National Unity in Nepal", in 900-500 BC, Aryans from the confluence of Ganges and Jamuna were the early migrants to inhabit, what we today call, the hilly region of Nepal (or simply 'Pahad'). Thus, the people residing in this region utilized the resources, established their native culture and language and obtained political authority in that area. Later when Madheshis arrived to reside, the early settlers dominated them. As per the modern history of Nepal, which is believed to have started after Pritihivi Narayan Shah's annexation of states, it was found that vital political posts, privileges, and power resided on the presumed

upper caste people (mostly residing in the hilly region), their native language and culture. The same inequality that could be seen in distribution of socio-economic and political rights created a base for the red-hot identity revolution which erupted in 1990 as the then Panchayat government harshly dominated the Madhesi people.

The early 1950s had a few politically aware people, continuously educating and awaring the illiterates on the state's domination, inequality and identity issues. In the same period, Bedananda Jha had advocated for the use of native Hindi language as official language through his Nepal-Terai Congress Party. So, the revolution was an outcome of the marginalized who were aware and noticed the series of the state's domination towards them. In 1954, The National Planning Commission made a declaration to make "Nepali", a language to be used for both official works and education, and was amended by the people's government led by BP Koirala, also including Hindi language as an official part of Madhesh in 1959. But, as the autocratic regime reinstated, it took domination to a harsh level. In 1959, king Mahendra introduced "Daura, Suruwal, topi" and nepali language as a significance of Nationality stating "Hamro Bhasa Hamro Bhesh Pran Bhandha Pyaro Chha". The definition of nationality then was not inclusive enough to address the native tongue and dress of Madheshis, despite having a diverse culture within Nepal. Later, the Citizenship amendment act of 1964 made it mandatory for citizens to speak and write in Nepali in order to obtain citizenship. It barred significant madheshi to obtain land ownership and other political rights and benefits. The resettlement plan of the 1980s addressed Madheshis as migrants and proceeded to finance the Pahadi people to make settlements in Terai, exploiting the resources and further dominating the Madheshi. There has been significant economic inequality between these two groups for a long time. The questioning

and suspicion regarding their nationality is worsened due to the open border between India and Nepal. The unmonitored to and fro travel through the borders have always made the Madheshi the prime concern for the initiation of identity-politics. However, an increase in socio-political awareness among the marginalized people, and the political environment all over the country did fuel the revolution.

After the Constitution of 1990 was promulgated, there was a requirement for an increase of parliamentary constituencies in Terai because the population had increased considerably from 43 percent in 1991 to 48 percent in the 2001 census. However, this requirement was never considered leaving Madheshi feeling excluded. In 2006, November the constitution was amended which promised citizenship to those born before 1990 but failed to address those born after 1990. Terai-based political parties began the Madhesh Andolan (Madhesh Movement) against the constitution, which couldn't guarantee their rights. The movement turned into a violent conflict in which the data of over 200 abductions and 85 killings since December 2006 was released by UNHCR in February 2008. The violence was stopped with the 22 Points Agreement which facilitated them to participate in the Constitutional Assembly (CA) Election on April 10, 2008.

It was believed that the Constitution of Nepal 2015 would address their demands from the 22 points agreement, however it didn't. That's when the Madhesh movement took a violent turn that resulted in the deaths of approximately 45 people. As documented by Human Rights Watch, thousands were injured as well.

The Madheshi revolution ensured a significant breakthrough in shaping the political institution of the country. Still, it seemed to have been derailed from the common demands of the people. Lately, political activism seemed to revolve around the interests of few egocentric leaders and geopolitical players. Incidents like Gaur Hatyakanda seemed to bring extremism in the movement and on the other hand also increased the faultline between the

ethnic group. Unnaturally close ties with the Indian ally, supporting the blockades of goods in Nepal-India border, harsh protests against the promulgation of Constitution of Nepal 2015 led to further resentment. The demonstration of this outrage was seen on 24 August, in Tikapur Municipality, where seven policemen as well as an 18-month-old boy were killed by protesters. But the lives were not only taken by the protesters, as 16 members of public in 5 Terai districts with no association with violence were killed within a month of this horrific event, as reported by the same.

After all these years of political turmoil, identity-politics has played a vital role to ensure the much deserved recognition to a handful of Madheshi leaders in vital political posts. But the reforms that those leaders were supposed to do is still questionable. The socio-political and economical position of the people still does not seem to have increased significantly. According to Central Bureau of Statistics 2011, economics status of Brahmin, Chhetri, Dalit and Janajati caste of hilly and Terai region was studied and it was found that 29.334% of people of Terai origin are under the poverty line. As reported by The New Humanitarian, more than 40% of the Madheshi still do not have citizenship or voting rights and only 15% of the 330 Nepalese parliamentarians are Madheshi.

The greater question that haunts Madheshi till date is their nationality, and the barrier between politics and people has caused this question to arise in the first place. Now the time has come for the people of Terai to come out and be politically aware, be it to vote out their so-called leaders who have derailed the prime agenda of Terai just to fulfill their vested interests, or to choose their bonafide leaders who will thrive not to make Terai a separate autonomous region in the name of development but to make it a stronger spine of the whole country for the collective growth of Terai and the nation.

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